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Will state deliver \$150M for CPS?

Support exists among lawmakers, but path to make it happen steep

By Kate Armanini, A.D. Quig and Olivia Olander
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

When Chicago Public Schools passed its \$9.96 billion budget on Thursday night, several board members made a high-stakes gamble: that state lawmakers will deliver \$150 million in additional funding.

The Chicago Teachers Union and its board allies argued that CPS is chronically underfunded by the state, and that the amended 2026-27 spending plan would restore hundreds of positions lost to layoffs and shield classrooms from cuts.

But CPS leaders, including CEO Macqueline King, issued a sharp warning. Building a budget around uncertain money could deter lenders, officials said, threatening the district's ability to secure short-term borrowing and make payroll. And, if the funding fails to materialize, schools across the district could face even deeper cuts.

"We are still working through what this decision by the board means for CPS, legally and financially," King said in a letter to families Friday. "At this point, we do not know if this will impact the opening of schools on Aug. 24."

The entire Board of Education has expressed support for lobbying for additional state money. CPS is funded at just 73% under the state's own evidence-based funding formula, which aims to steer revenue to the neediest districts in Illinois. But while there's broad agreement that the district needs more funding, there's far less consensus over how to get it.

CTU and allied board members say the amended budget is a pressure tactic designed to force state lawmakers to act. Several legislators, including embattled Illinois House Speaker Emanuel "Chris" Welch, said they'll work to pass a supplemental funding bill — though it remains unclear where that money will come from in the state's budget.

"There's no revenue currently for what they've described," Gov.

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DREAM DEFERRED

By Daniel C. Vock and Gregory Royal Pratt
FOR THE CHICAGO TRIBUNE

WASHINGTON — At a tidy Lutheran church near the U.S. Capitol in mid-July, Tereza Lee, a 43-year-old professional musician who has performed at Carnegie Hall and with the Chicago Symphony Orchestra, sat at a grand piano near the wooden altar and played a portion of Frédéric Chopin's iconic "Fantaisie-Imromptu."

In the pews, more than a dozen well-dressed young Black, Hispanic and Asian men and women gathered for an unusual ceremony. They wore caps and gowns of various colors — mostly black, but also shades of blue and cardinal red — from colleges across the country. One decorated her green cap with flowers, a butterfly and the message: "Dreams without borders. Gracias mami y papi."

At a place of honor up front sat U.S.

Sen. Durbin's quarter-century fight for the DREAM Act remains illusory, but its effects are real

Above: Sen. Dick Durbin cheers with dreamers on July 22 at the Lutheran Church of the Reformation on Capitol Hill in Washington during a mock graduation event to commemorate Durbin's long advocacy for the DREAM Act, a path to citizenship for undocumented people brought to the U.S. as children. Tereza Lee, right, was his inspiration for the legislation. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

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A pastor became an oilman. Spills and pollution followed

At least 11 overflows linked to Indian Liberty's roughly 1,400 wells

By Jonathan Bullington and Adriana Pérez
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

LAWRENCE COUNTY — Tens of thousands of gallons of fluid spilled from the open pit, urged on by heavy spring rains and unencumbered by an emergency pump disabled by a power failure.

The toxic mix of oil and an underground water called brine, several times saltier than the ocean, poured into a ditch along Petrolia Lane and crept toward an unnamed stream.

It then flowed for 3 miles along a serpentine creek, heading east and north en route to the Embarras River. From there, the current

of the river known downstate as the "Ambraw" took it toward the Wabash River along the Illinois-Indiana state line.

An Illinois Department of Natural Resources conservation police officer spotted the unmistakable sheen of oil on the Ambraw that morning in March 2024 and alerted local emergency management officials and the state agency.

Some 150 miles southwest at the far southern tip of the state, utility company Illinois American Water was told to be ready to operate an emergency intake on the Ohio River, downstream of the Wabash, as a last resort to prevent the contaminants from polluting the Mississippi River and, ultimately, the Gulf of Mexico.

Over the next few days, a network of at least 30 divisions within local,



Indian Liberty Boyd facility on Petrolia Lane in downstate Bridgeport on July 20. The 140-square-foot open pit is where, according to state records, a spill originated in March 2024. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/TRIBUNE**

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SPORTS For Cubs, Sox, help wanted

Trade deadlines come and go, but the "savior" narrative never fades, writes columnist Paul Sullivan. This year's big haul? Tigers ace Tarik Skubal, but he's unlikely to land in Chicago.

NATION & WORLD Trump's threat for Iran

President Donald Trump threatened more strikes on Iran on Saturday as the U.S. presses for the reopening of the Strait of Hormuz and uncertainty grips the region. **Page B5**

CHICAGOLAND Responses to Benton report

Following the release of the report on disgraced former state Rep. Harry Benton, there were two opposite responses. One from an ex-staffer and one from the Illinois speaker. **Page A3**

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